I do not want to leave the reader with the impression that medieval India was only about the building, pillaging, abandoning and rebuilding of cities. One must remember that most of the population lived in rural areas. Babur tells us that Indian villagers rarely invested in either irrigation or in building permanent homes. Instead, they were ever prepared to abandon their villages and take refuge in the forests. [27] This is how the common people had coped with the previous three centuries of invasion and war. Much of the country remained forested and, in some cases, may have reverted to wilderness after habitations were abandoned. There were forests just outside Delhi, where its rulers indulged in hunting within a few hours' ride from the city walls. Feroze Shah even built a number of hunting lodges along the Aravalli ridges, including one in what is now the urban village of Mahipalpur, very close to the international airport. Deer, leopards and possibly lions were found where bright neon lights now announce budget hotels. British records speak of the 'Hurriana lion' as late as the 1820s. [28]

THE MUGHAL HUNT

Babur's diary expresses his disdain for the people of India in barely a couple of paragraphs but he was more impressed by the flora and fauna of the country and spent several pages describing them. Babur tells us about peacocks, elephants and river dolphins. He was particularly intrigued by the rhinoceros that he encountered in forests near Peshawar. It is interesting that rhinos were found so far to the west in the sixteenth century. They are now found only in the swampy grasslands of Assam, North Bengal and Nepal's Terai regions. Oddly, Babur does not mention the big cats. It is possible that he had encountered lions and cheetahs in Afghanistan and northeastern Iran and did not think of them as uniquely Indian.

The Mughals were enthusiastic hunters whose expeditions are recorded in numerous writings and in paintings. They hunted a wide array of animals including nilgai, blackbuck, birds and, of course, lions. Note that there are relatively fewer accounts and paintings related to hunting tigers. This may merely reflect the fact that the Mughals did most of their hunting in the